

FIELD OF VISION SHARDA UGRA

Sania's Glass Ceiling



By the time this appears, Sania Mirza could have been knocked out of the US Open. Or she could still be in the singles draw at Flushing Meadows, sending India's collective pulse skyrocketing. Either way it doesn't matter. Mirza's future is not linked to either her ranking or to her fate at the last Grand Slam of the year. Her fate is tied to her next step up the ladder. Well after she made that ladder seem human-scale for all Indian girls, it continues to test her.

Mirza's place in Indian tennis history is safe, sealed. The real worth of what happens next will be understood acutely only by the sassy player and her family. She is now playing the kind of tennis where, on a good day, she can beat most women players in the top 20. Most, not all. To churn up the 'creamy layer' that sits atop the women's game—the Williams', Maria Sharapova, Justine Henin, will take everything she owns and then some.

Mirza has broken down many doors, but this happens to be the strongest one. Father Imran, who has planned her career meticulously and independently, says that she is most "capable of a stray win" against the top five players but will need to improve "quite a bit before she is ready to beat them regularly". 'Regularly' implies joining their company.

Mirza has shown enormous will to come back from a career-threatening knee injury and surgery. She took to a strenuous physical regime with a resolve that surprised even her parents. The results were evident on the US hard courts as, leaner and quicker to the ball, she came raging back into India's consciousness again. With five wins over top-20 players since the end of July, Mirza has earned more street cred on road and a seeding into the US Open.

What is under examination now is whether the hard-court run has stoked just hunger and ambition, or also the appetite for more hard labour. After five fairly fruitful years on the pro tour, Lindsay Davenport gave herself to a tougher fitness routine and went from a good top 10 player to a three-time Grand Slam title winner and four-time finalist. Even today, Justine Henin puts her 5-ft 5-inch, 57-kg frame through punishing physical work to keep up with the power players.

For Mirza, the push upward will be tougher than anything she has ever attempted before. It will require a Grandmaster's forward-thinking, a monk's discipline and a gambler's daring. If ever we wanted to know what Sania Mirza was all about, we will find out now.



SAURABH SINGH

SEEDHI BAAT ON AAJ TAK

"Today people want instant success"

SINGER ALKA YAGNIK SPOKE TO EDITOR PRABHU CHAWLA about her music, the industry and how it has changed

Q. Why are you fighting with the other judges of Star Voice of India?

A. I'm not fighting; it's just an argument. Everyone is emotionally charged in *Star Voice of India*.

Q. Which was your first song?

A. In *Payal Ki Jhankar* I had sung only four lines. My first real song was a duet in *Hamari Bahu Alka*. But my first popular song was Kalyanji-Anandji's *Mere angne mein*. I was just 15 years old then.

Q. Why did you sing Choli ke peechhe?

A. I am a shy person, but Laxmikantji told me that as an artist I have to forget everything to sing this song. He also said that the song was not for a vamp but Madhuri Dixit would perform on it.

Q. Earlier, actors were identified by the voices of singers. Is that missing now?

A. Yes. Earlier, only four or five actors dominated the industry. But now we have many actors and singers. So the work has been divided and distributed.

Q. People compare you with Lata Mangeshkar.

A. Please don't compare me with Lata Mangeshkar. She is a great singer. People compare me with her just to make me happy.

Q. You started your career singing for the radio. Then you sang bhajans and ghazals.

A. My mother is a classical singer. I always wanted to become a playback singer. When I was five I started singing bhajans on radio in Kolkata. In my entire career, I've sung ghazals only for J.P. Dutta's *Umraao Jaan*.

Q. What kind of songs do you like?

A. I like melodious, semi-classical and romantic songs. However, some of my item songs such as *Ek do teen* and *Chamma chamma* are very popular.

Q. Why is the music industry in a mess today?

A. Today people believe in instant success. Music should be eternal but these days it is short-lived. Music directors like Laxmikant-Pyarelal and Naushad were our pillars. But we still have good music directors like Nadeem-Shravan, Jatin-Lalit, Anu Malik and A.R. Rehman. Their music and songs are evergreen.

Seedhi Baat is telecast on Aaj Tak at 8.30 p.m. every Sunday and 3.30 p.m. every Monday



MANDAR DEODHAR

Full text of the interview at:

<http://www.indiatoday.com>

